

Wild Strawberry

Fragaria virginiana

Virginia Strawberry · Mountain Strawberry



QUALITIES

A spreading native perennial groundcover 4 to 6 inches tall, with characteristic three-leaflet (trifoliate) compound leaves on slender stalks. White five-petaled flowers with bright yellow centers appear in May and June, followed by small red strawberries in June and July — true strawberries, smaller but more intensely flavored than commercial varieties. Spreads aggressively by surface runners (stolons) to form a dense knit-together mat.

CARE

Full sun to part shade; tolerates a wide range of soils from sandy loam to clay. Drought-tolerant once established. Hardy to USDA Zone 3. Plant from plug or 4-inch container 12 inches apart; will fill in within two seasons. Fully steppable. No pest or disease issues in residential settings. Removes runners as needed if you want to contain spread.

HISTORY

Fragaria virginiana is one of the two parent species of the modern cultivated strawberry (*Fragaria × ananassa*) — the cultivated berry is a hybrid produced in 1750s France between this North American species and the Chilean strawberry. The Anishinaabe called wild strawberry "ode'imín" (heart berry) and considered it sacred; June was traditionally Strawberry Moon (Ode'imín Giizis). The leaves have been used for tea since pre-contact times across most of the species' range.

REASON TO BE

Wild Strawberry is one of the few truly edible native groundcovers — the tiny berries that you (or the robins) harvest in June are real strawberries, concentrated in flavor. The flowers feed early-season native bees; the leaves host the larvae of the Grey Hairstreak butterfly. As a ground-hugging tough native, it converts the service-area buffer or any path edge from sterile mulch into ecologically functional habitat — and gives you something to taste in passing.